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The Turing Test vs. the Chinese Room: Taking a Position

The idea that a machine can think is a controversial one. In 1950, Alan Turing suggested that if a computer can successfully convince an average investigator that it was human in the Imitation Game, it provides an alternative way of handling the "can machines think" question (Turing 433). However, arguments such as the Searle's Chinese Room are used to refute this claim (Oppy and Dowe). The Chinese Room refers to how an English person following an instruction set to respond fluently in Chinese does not have to understand Chinese to respond. This can be linked to Turing's claim as saying a response does not correlate to understanding and so cannot be an indicator of thought. I am inclined to agree with Searle, but the Other Minds reply to his claim is partially agreeable to me. With the ever growing use of AI, humans should ponder these arguments as they can affect how we develop our relationship with them.

How can one know what someone else perceives? There is no real way to know and even if humans agree on an answer, the way we get it can significantly differ. For example, Stanford Encyclopedia of Philosophy notes that mathematical savant Daniel Tammet goes through colors when expanding pi beyond a certain point (Cole). Another person would not experience said colors or if they did it would not be the same colors, so they do not share Tammet's pi method. If humans do not need to share the same trains of thought to get an answer, then neither does a machine. In the same way another human's mind is a black box, we can say the mind of any other entity to be the same. Humans attribute thoughts to others because of their behaviour. We cannot tell what animals are thinking, at most guess based on various studies, yet they must be thinking if they are acting. The thoughts of a machine could be so foreign for a human that we could not recognize it even with full knowledge of their underlying process. Even if the process

by which a response is generated seems to leave no room for understanding to form, we cannot determine the absence of thought.

Searle's response was that the question he is asking is not about the thoughts of others but rather about how thoughts cannot just be computation alone. This is founded in the idea of assuming the existence of understanding in humans in cognitive science in a similar manner to physical objects in physics (Searle 422). By this logic, humans with the right output can either understand or not understand so having the right output has no direct correlation to understanding. The Chinese room aims to show that the instruction set (the program in the case of a computer) is not enough to generate understanding. However that begs the question, why that assumption cannot be extended to machines. Many critics ask this same question (Oppy and Dowe). If we deny this assumption for machines, then why not deny it for humans too. We do not know what exact attribute gives understanding to human brains. Then it cannot be said whether a machine is lacking this attribute.

Turing and Searle's claims are still relevant today. The question of whether there is true thought behind interactions with increasingly human-like Large Language Models (LLMs) is important for people who attribute thought to AI. For example, apps have been created where one can interact with an AI generated character on a regular basis. These interactions can better or worsen a poor mental state (Peter et al. 6-7). For people who interact with such AI characters, they become very immersed as such project human values onto the AI. The reason for this immersion is that these AI characters are very humanlike and can even be modified to be a very suitable companion as decided by the user or by adapting to the user. If they experience a situation where their immersion is broken, that can have a negative impact on their mental health which in the worst case leads to extreme actions such as suicide. Then if the question of can a

machine think had a clear answer, the number of immersed people may decrease or the way they handle broken immersion may not be as problematic. People would have preexisting notions when interacting with AI regardless of the exact nature of its thought, whether it exists or not. With this certainty some people can avoid attributing humanity to AI and so have a more objective view of their relationship with it. In the cases where people are immersed, methods for handling extreme cases may be better developed.

Neither Turing's claim nor Searle's claim directly answer the question, can a machine think. However, Searle's argument that the cause of thought cannot be a program is convincing though not without gaps. The Other Minds reply points out that we cannot know the minds of other entities whether human or machine and Searle responds by highlighting the assumption that understanding exists in humans due to a property of their brains. There is a possibility of this property already existing in machines or granting this property to machines. The relevance of these arguments is still high considering character AI apps. Getting a definite answer to can a machine think would affect humans' relationship with AI thereby better the way AI related mental incidents are handled.

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